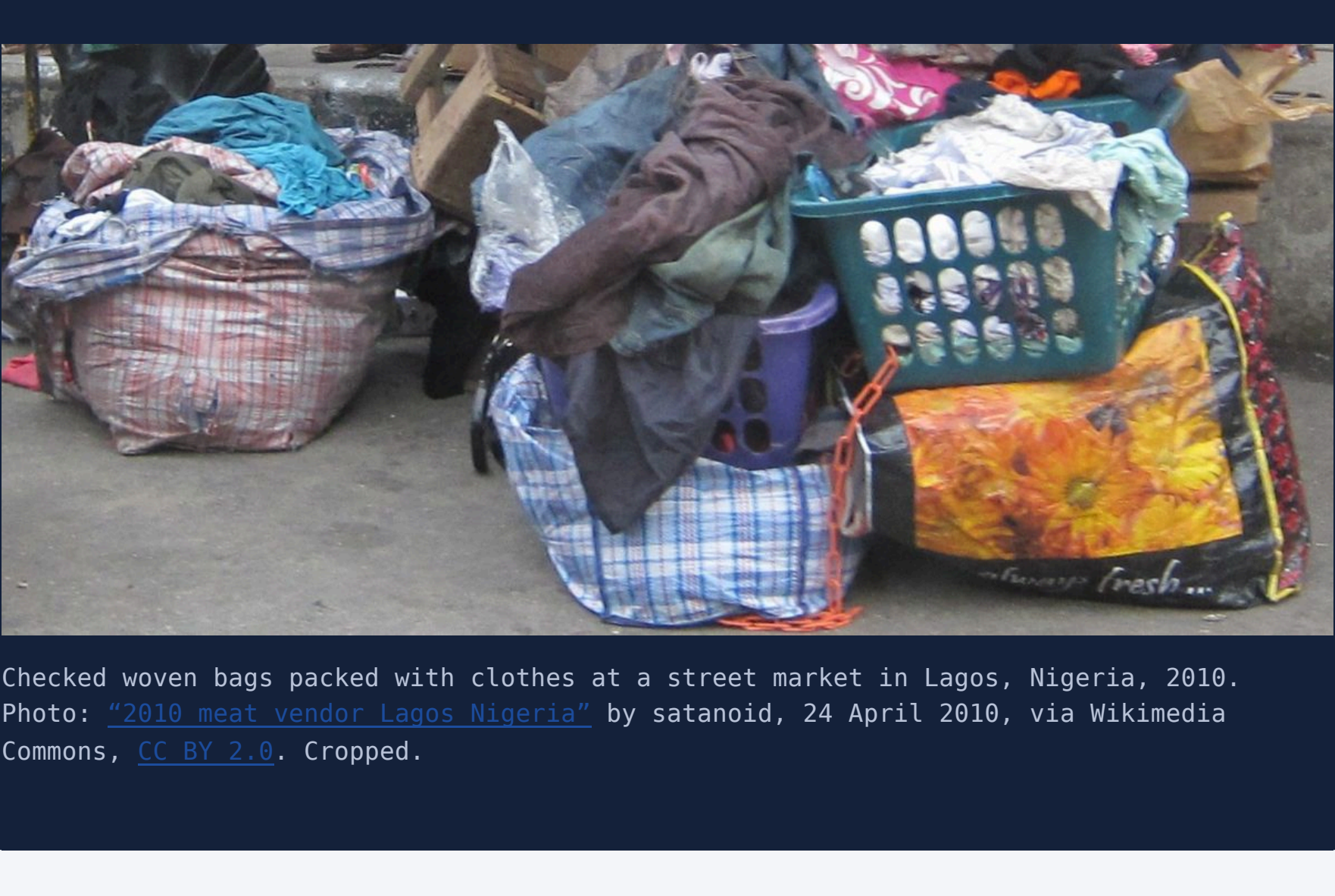
WHO OWNS MEMORY? · MIGRATION, DISPLACEMENT, MINORITIES & BELONGING

GHANA MUST GO

The bag that outlived its memory

A web story by Doris Anderson · October 2026



Checked woven bags packed with clothes at a street market in Lagos, Nigeria, 2010. Photo: “2010 meat vendor Lagos Nigeria” by satanoid, 24 April 2010, via Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0. Cropped.

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ONE

YOU KNOW THE BAG. DO YOU KNOW THE STORY?

You have probably seen it at a market, a bus station or an airport carousel. It is cheap, light and strong, and it holds more than it looks able to.

Across West Africa, people call it Ghana Must Go. The bag is easy to recognise. The name is harder to explain. Why does an ordinary carrier bag bear the name of one country and an order to leave?

Before you read on: did you know where the name comes from?

Yes, I knew

No, I didn’t

RECORD	TESTIMONY	INTERPRETATION
What historians and institutions document.	What people say in their own words.	What this story argues from that evidence.

TWO

A NAME THAT CAME FROM HISTORY

RECORD The bag itself has no single home. The historian Samuel Fury Childs Daly describes it as one of the woven plastic bags, often printed in plaid, that people across the Global South use to carry clothes, produce and trade goods.[1]

The name is far more specific. Daly traces it to Nigeria’s expulsion of Ghanaians in 1983. After that deportation the bags became known as “Ghana-Must-Go”, first in Nigerian Pidgin and then across West Africa.[1] Leicester Museums, which holds an artwork based on the bag, notes that the name began as a derogatory one.[4]

INTERPRETATION The object was already in use and already ordinary. The event gave it a new name.

GHANA	MUST	GO
A country, used here to mean its people living abroad.	An order. In January 1983 it came from a government.	A direction: out of Nigeria, west along the coast.

Three words that turned a carrier bag into a record of an expulsion. Graphic by Doris Anderson.

THREE

1983: WHEN “GO” BECAME A COMMAND

RECORD Nigeria’s oil economy boomed in the 1970s and drew workers from across the region. By the end of the decade the boom had turned to bust. Daly writes that Nigerian politicians deflected attention from their own mismanagement by blaming Ghanaians for taking Nigerian jobs.[1]

On 17 January 1983, the Minister of Internal Affairs, Alhaji Ali Baba, announced on television that unskilled migrants had to leave the country by the end of the month.[1] The government expected that most people would comply without being forced. In Daly’s words, “they would deport themselves.”[1]

The numbers are disputed. Ghana’s High Commission estimated that about one million Ghanaians were deported. Daly judges the true figure to be lower, though still in the hundreds of thousands.[1]

This was one episode in a longer exchange. Ghana had expelled Nigerians and other migrants under its Aliens Compliance Order of November 1969, and Nigeria ordered a second, smaller expulsion in May 1985.[1,5]

1969 · 1970s · Late 70s · 17 Jan 1983 · 1985 · 2007 · 2023

1983

NIGERIA EXPELS

On television, Nigeria orders unskilled migrants to leave by the end of the month. The bag gets its name.

← Earlier

Later →

▶ Play the story

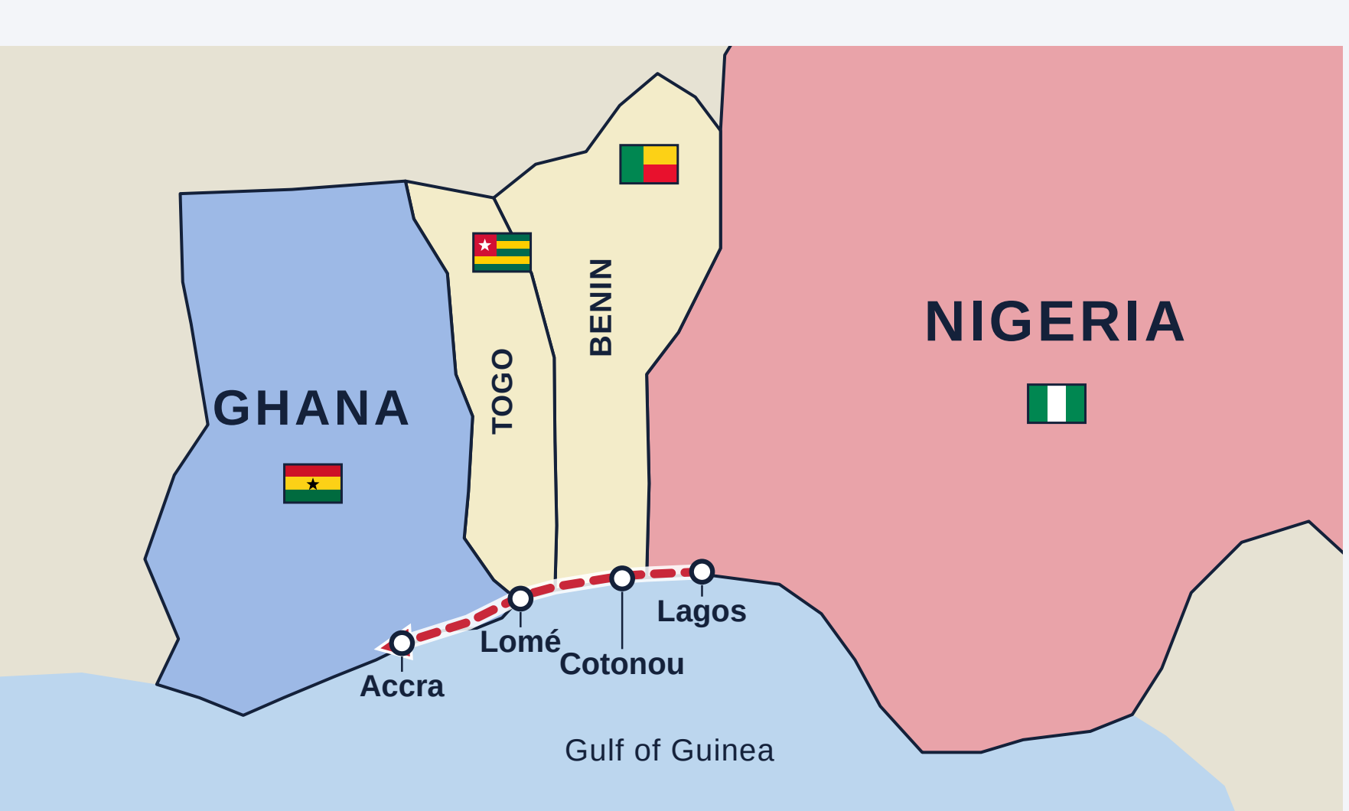
4 of 7

Step through the years, or press play. Timeline by Doris Anderson, from Daly (2023), MIDEQ (2023) and Marie Claire UK.

FOUR

WHAT CAN A BAG CARRY?

RECORD Two weeks is not long to close down a life. The road home ran west through two other countries, Benin and Togo. Research by the MIDEQ migration project describes the bags as what deported migrants used to carry their personal belongings.[2]



NIGERIA	BENIN	TOGO	GHANA
Lagos. The order is given here.	Cotonou. First border.	Lomé. Second border.	Accra. Third border, and home.

The coastal route, east to west. Sketch map by Doris Anderson: borders are simplified and approximate. Each country is marked with its national flag.

TESTIMONY The journalist Shola Lawal spoke to Ghanaians who made that journey. One of them, Solomon Asiedu, had been working in Lagos. He told her:

> **“I was not ready to leave.”**
>
> Solomon “Acquaye” Asiedu, quoted by Shola Lawal[5]

RECORD Lawal also reports that Ghana’s own government closed its border with Togo for a time, leaving vehicles backed up along the road to Lagos and people stranded in the heat without water.[5]

One voice cannot stand for everyone. MIDEQ’s interviews with Ghanaians who lived in Nigeria in 1983 also recorded positive feelings towards Nigerians, and traced the expulsion to an anti-migrant narrative led by the state.[2]

FIVE

WHEN AN OBJECT BECOMES MEMORY

INTERPRETATION Nothing about the bag changed in 1983. It was the same woven plastic, the same check, the same zip. What changed was the word people used for it. Since then, each time someone asks for a Ghana Must Go in a market, the order of January 1983 is spoken again, whether or not the speaker knows it.

That is how an everyday object comes to carry collective memory. The memory is held in the name, in daily use, and in the hands of people who never set out to commemorate anything.

RECORD Some people have chosen to remember on purpose. In 2023, the Migration Advocacy Centre Ghana, MIDEQ researchers and local artists marked the fortieth anniversary with an exhibition built around the bags, and with a documentary film, *Omo Ghana, Man For Chop*.[2,3] One participant said:

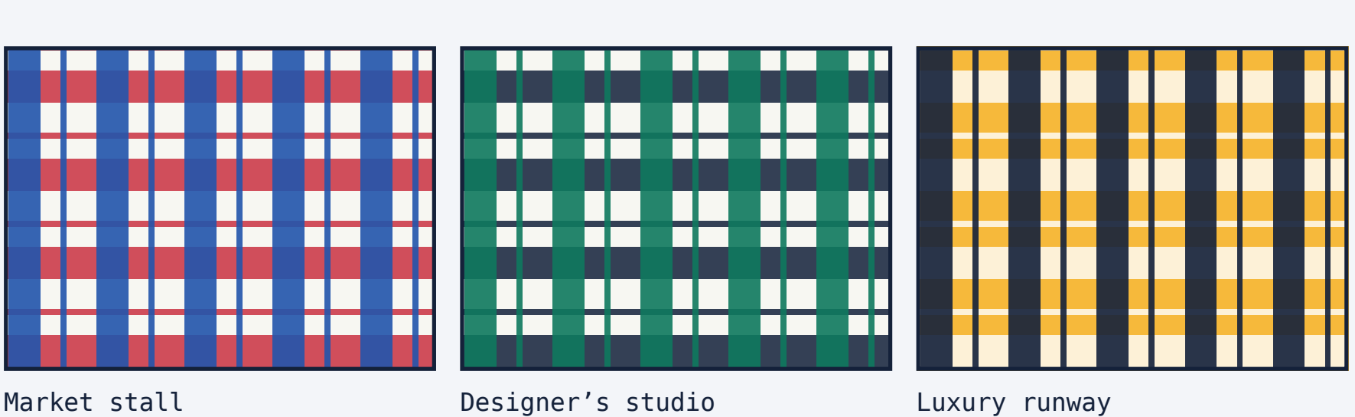
> **“This is a very good programme that is going to cast our minds back to our heritage, what we went through …”**
>
> Participant at the exhibition opening, quoted by MIDEQ[2]

In Britain, the Ghanaian-born artist Anthony Amoako-Attah remade the bag in screen-printed glass and called it *Take Me Home*.[4]

SIX

RECLAIMED, OR REWRITTEN?

RECORD The check has also left the market for the studio and the runway. Louis Vuitton showed a plaid laundry tote under Marc Jacobs for spring/summer 2007.[6,7] Aisha Ayensu, founder of the label Christie Brown, referenced the pattern throughout its autumn/winter 2025 collection.[6]



Market stall · Designer’s studio · Luxury runway

One check, three lives. The colourways are invented for this graphic and copy no brand’s design. Graphic by Doris Anderson.

TESTIMONY People who work with the pattern do not describe a wound that has simply healed. The visual artist Òbìnna Òbíòmà says the print captures a duality:

> **“… it holds the memory of displacement while also celebrating movement, identity, and renewal.”**
>
> Òbìnna Òbíòmà, quoted in *Marie Claire* UK[6]

The stylist Marian Kwei says that for some it is a painful reminder of the 1983 expulsion.[6] The designer Papa Oppong, quoted in the *Cape Times*, puts the claim differently: “We’re asserting that our utilitarian objects are worthy of design innovation on our own terms.”[7]

INTERPRETATION The bag’s meaning is being reshaped. A name that began as an insult is now also worn with pride. Whether that reclaims the story or leaves it behind depends on who is doing the remaking, and on whether the history travels with the pattern.

SEVEN

WHEN THE OBJECT SURVIVES THE MEMORY

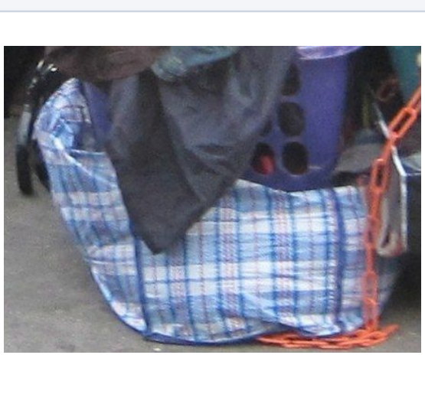
RECORD The bag is still everywhere, and so is its name.

Carrier bags for sale at a market in Ghana, 2013, with checked woven bags among them. Photo: “Polythene bags on Ghanaian markets” by SandisterTei, 12 April 2013, via Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0. Cropped; this cropped version is shared under the same licence.

The history behind the name has travelled less well. Daly observes:

> **“Few people today connect the bags to the historical event that gave them this name, even though it was not very long ago.”**
>
> Samuel Fury Childs Daly[1]

INTERPRETATION This is the limit of what an object can remember for us. A name can outlast the knowledge of what it once meant. For many people who use it now, “Ghana Must Go” is simply what the bag is called.



GHANA MUST GO

An order broadcast on 17 January 1983
About two weeks to leave Nigeria
Three borders between Lagos and home
One bag for whatever could be carried

Drag from 1983 towards today: 1983

1983 ● 2026

The bag and its name stay. The story behind them fades. This graphic illustrates the argument of this section. It does not measure what people know. Graphic by Doris Anderson; photo detail from “2010 meat vendor Lagos Nigeria” by satanoid, CC BY 2.0, cropped.

EIGHT

WHAT DOES THE BAG REMEMBER?

A bag cannot tell its own story. It can only keep a name ready for someone to ask about.

So who owns this memory? The people who were told to go, and who are growing old? The two countries that expelled each other’s citizens? The designers who have put the check on a runway? Or anyone who carries one home from the market?

The next time you see the bag, say its name, and then ask what it meant in January 1983.

SOURCES

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All sources were accessed on 5 October 2026.

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- Sketch map and route, Lagos to Accra. Created by Doris Anderson for this project.
- “One check, three lives” swatches. Created by Doris Anderson for this project.
- Interactive “the story fades” graphic. Created by Doris Anderson for this project.

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

Made by Doris Anderson for *Who Owns Memory?*, a digital public history project, in the thematic group Migration, Displacement, Minorities & Belonging. The story asks how an everyday object becomes a carrier of collective memory, and what happens when the object stays recognisable while the history behind it fades.